

Butterflies & Moths

Gone, for the moment, are the summer-like warm days we've enjoyed. And some butterflies – caught glimpses of Brimstone, Peacock and Small Tortoiseshell.

Here are some to look out for in April



Comma



Small Tortoiseshell



Peacock



Brimstone



Whites Small & Large



Orange Tip



Speckled Wood



Painted Lady



Red Admiral

Wild Flowers

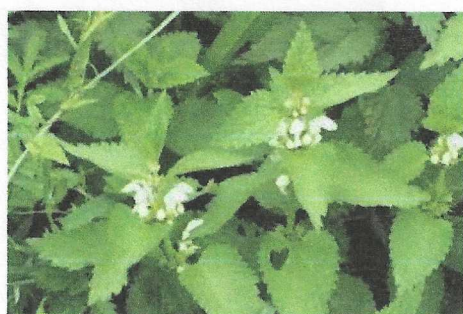
Flowers in the hedges and edges in this month of April



Daisies



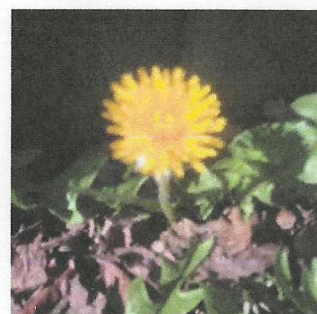
Lesser Stitchwort



White Dead Nettle



Self-heal



Dandelion



Groundsel



Celandines



Violets



and in the wood *Purple Wood Anemone*

Trees

So many shades of green now. And what variety in the trees' development!

Starting in Dr Jack's



Hawthorne



Hazel



Privet



Poplar

Sycamores in the woodland and on its park edge by the cricket covers



In April



In March

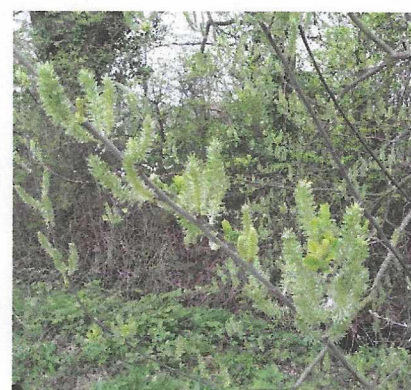
On the eastern edge of the playing field alongside the footpath



Mountain Ash

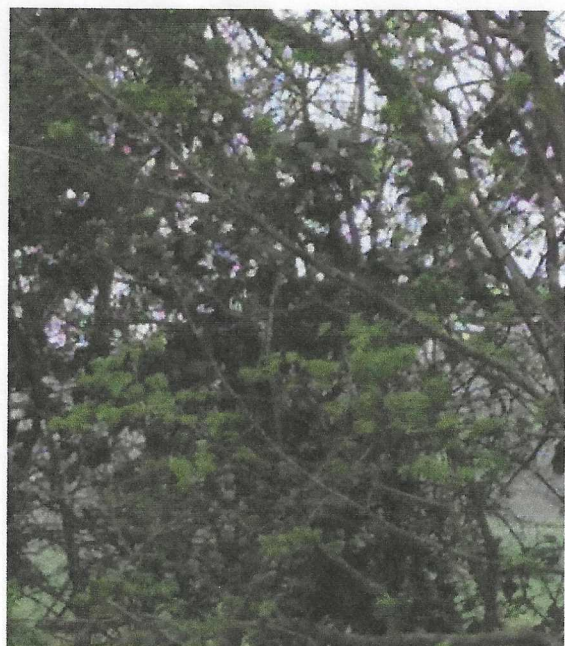


Willow in March

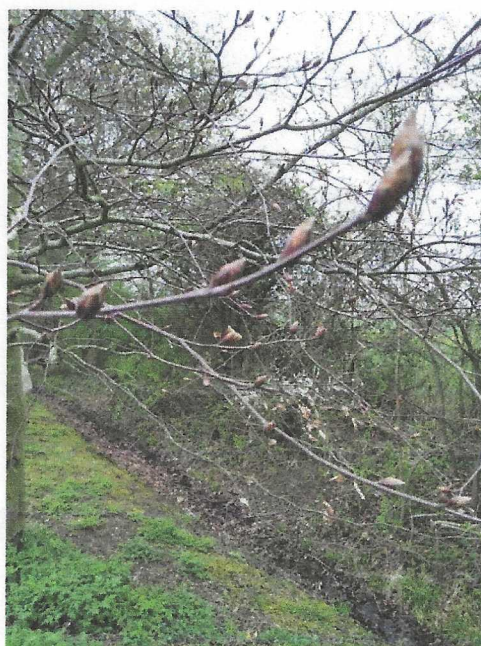


and in April

Trees



The earliest of the oaks to burst its buds



and of the 3 Beeches, only the one on the right is bursting its buds.



And one of the Horse Chestnuts – looks as if it won't be long before it's in blossom!

Birds

This month's bird is the Magpie

The Magpie, *Pica pica*, is a member of the corvidae family – along with crows, ravens, rooks, jackdaws, jays, choughs, and nutcrackers. Known as the crow family, or, more technically, corvids



It's easily distinguishable with its black-and-white- plumage, its long tail and its noisy chattering.



Not altogether black-and-white though. A closer look reveals a green gloss to its tail and purplish-blue iridescent sheen on its wing feathers

Its walking is confident, high-stepping and has brisk sideways hops and jumps. When excited it raises and fans its tail.



Apparently, the longer its tail the higher its rank.

High-ranking birds can initiate ceremonial gatherings, usually before the breeding season with plenty of noise in an attempt to obtain a territory. They attract participants with noisy chatter but are often driven off by the audience.

Birds



They mate for life, stay in the same territory and build their nests, roofed and with side entrance, high up in trees, usually thorny, or in a bush.

They eat beetles, fruits and seeds, small birds and other birds' eggs and nestlings as well as carrion, refuse and domestic scraps. A very opportunistic feeder- no problem living close to humans.



Rossini's *The Thieving Magpie* was based on the myth that they're attracted to and steal shiny objects.

Like other Corvids Magpies display remarkable intelligence for animals of their size and are among the most intelligent birds. Magpies especially have demonstrated self-awareness in mirror tests.

If you're suspicious - what do you say if you see a magpie on its own?

On seeing Magpies poem

One for sorrow, two for joy
Three for a girl and four for a boy
Five for silver, six for gold
Seven for a secret never to be told
Eight for a wish, nine for a kiss
Ten for a smile you must not miss